members and this gathering is a key event in its annual diplomatic calendar. It found considerable value in the ADMM Plus gathering of Defence Ministers as well.

The more structured processes have been buttressed by the informal and ad hoc ones as well. Among the arrangements that India works with today are the ReCAAP agreement on combating piracy in Asia and, as a funnel state, the cooperation mechanism in the Straits of Malacca and Singapore. The regional engagement is strengthened by a broad range of bilateral defence and security relationships with all members of ASEAN and, indeed, of the EAS as well. Because the ASEAN style is consensual and soft spoken, the value it brings to the table is often underestimated.

Noteworthy as this unfolding story of cooperation is, its real importance actually lies in the deeper significance that the post-1991 era has had for the reform of the Indian polity. A few years ago, there was a bumper crop of books on the 1991 economic crisis, some of them centring around Prime Minister Narasimha Rao. It was a natural occasion in India to debate the significance of those events. Tuning in from a foreign policy perspective, what came out was the critical role that ASEAN and Singapore especially played in shaping the thought processes of Indian decision makers. This was a forum for India to engage the world more expansively, test ideas, exchange views and seek feedback. Mentors of this region found a more-ready audience in a changing India. Their advice and experiences offered guidance as India moved along an uncharted path.

It was, therefore, only fitting that India acknowledged this debt through the presence of Prime Minister Modi at the funeral of Lee Kuan Yew, former Singapore Prime Minister, in 2015. Today, the changes underway in India are deeper and broader. A very determined effort is being made to expand manufacturing, transform infrastructure and enhance the quality of human resources. The formalization of the economy is also being accelerated, as indeed is the removal of impediments to its efficiency. It is highlighted by a commitment to make it easier to do business. Much of this transformation goes beyond narrow economic policies and involves social changes of differing magnitudes. Consequently, we have also seen awareness